the 2011 IAS batch, gathered in Mussoorie at their alma mater for a 'ten-year-reunion'. Nandan, currently the Union environment secretary, had previously written a thriller called *Ten Days* in 2014, and she clearly has a strong sense of plot. The sections that fictionalise the workings of the RAW are particularly enjoyable.

Finally, Reba Som's *Hop, Skip and Jump: Peregrinations of a Diplomat's Wife* delivers an invaluable perspective on the diplomatic life—what of their spouses and children who must compulsorily uproot their lives every three years, all in the name of serving the nation? Som's anecdotal style and eye for detail serve her well, and the stories she recalls are all quite charming. My only quibble is that it's not particularly well-edited; there are semi-frequent typos and glaring errors, like Mortal Kombat (the massive video-game and film franchise, erroneously spelt with a 'c' here) being misspelled at multiple places. On the whole, though, *Hop, Skip and Jump* remains a fun and light-hearted read.

In Indian pop culture, bureaucrats are often painted in broad strokes. They are either indolent pencil-pushers or formidable, Machiavellian manipulators, ignoring the fact that the overwhelming majority of people live somewhere in between those extremes. Read this quartet of books about the lives of IAS and IFS officers, and make up your own mind. ■

Aditya Mani Jha

BOOKS

STORY TIME

The Greatest Indian Stories Ever Told is an anthology to be savoured slowly

There is an old joke about reviewing a book without having read it. That is precisely what I am going to do with this one, for it deserves no less. We have here 50 of the greatest Indian stories ever told, as the title proclaims, and we must read them with due reverence and regard, at the rate perhaps of one story every day, or every week, or perhaps every month. We mustn't wolf down this feast fit for connoisseurs as we do a burger.

The editor Arunava Sinha is a prolific, astute and widely respected literary translator. To his credit, he himself in his 'Introduction' interrogates each word in the title—'greatest', 'Indian', 'story', 'ever', and even 'told' and 'the'—before the sceptical reader can do so. He rightly extols India's limitless literary and cultural diversity. And yet, in conclusion, he makes a hyperbolic claim of his own, that when we have finished reading this volume, we will know "why India is the greatest story ever told".

The 50 stories come from 15 different Indian languages, including Indian English, except that a story from Portuguese has slipped through as well; it is by Laxmanrao Sardessai, a Goan. Seven of the stories were written in English, while all the others are translated. In fact, they are culled from the 14 anthologies already published by this same publisher and similarly titled 'The Greatest Assamese/ Bengali/ Gujarati/ Hindi/ Urdu etc. Stories

THE 50 STORIES IN THIS ANTHOLOGY COME FROM 15 DIFFERENT INDIAN LANGUAGES, INCLUDING INDIAN ENGLISH, AND ONE FROM PORTUGUESE

Ever Told'. This anthology is thus double distilled, and the Greatest of the Greatest.

The stories are arranged here not by the date of original publication or by language but in the alphabetical order of the authors' surnames. This could be called the line of least resistance, but has the incidental virtue of pitting together the two Tharoors, father and son, which may possibly prompt some readers to ask why we have to have both.

Many authors included here are indeed among the greats: Sarat Chandra Chatterjee, Ismat Chughtai, Mahasweta Devi, Qurratulain Hyder, Kalki, R.K. Narayan, Premchand, Amrita Pritam, Fakir Mohan Senapati and Rabindranath Tagore. It's almost enough to make us forget that not to be found here are U.R. Ananthamurthy, Saadat Hasan Manto, Raja Rao and Nirmal Verma.

Unlike a novel, a short story must conclude no sooner than it has got going, and it is always fascinating to see which of the two major modes of ending it adopts: the Maupassant method of shutting with a clap or twist in the tale, or the Chekhov mode in which there is only a tentative closure and life drifts on beyond the last page. As I dutifully turned each page of the book, sampling titles and first lines, I was similarly struck by how many different ways there are of beginning a story and enticing the reader to stop and read on. ■

Harish Trivedi

THE GREATEST INDIAN STORIES EVER TOLD
Fifty Masterpieces From the Nineteenth Century to the Present
edited by Arunava Sinha
ALEPH
₹999; 528 pages

